



RANCHI | Arrested Development

From his pedestal of power, former Jharkhand chief minister Madhu Koda has joined the league of ignominy. Koda was arrested on November 30 in Chaibasa, 155 km from Ranchi, under the disproportionate asset case by the Jharkhand Vigilance Bureau. In a separate move, former cabinet minister and NCP leader Kamlesh Singh was also arrested on charges of owning assets disproportionate to his known sources of income. Seen through the political prism, the arrests appear aimed at denying the BJP its diatribes against the Congress just prior to the second phase of voting in the state elections. Koda has put up seven candidates—including his wife Geeta—in the polls under the aegis of his new party, Jharkhand Navnirman Morcha. But with Koda in jail and Geeta a greenhorn, it may be difficult to translate public curiosity into sympathy votes. Koda's arrest is also being viewed as the Congress's desperate attempts at distancing itself from a tainted Koda. The party was earlier struggling to deflect the BJP's accusations that it had propped up Koda as the chief minister and had supported him when he allegedly swindled public money. It was the BJP's major campaign point which could fetch the saffron squad some help during electioneering. But given the arrests, this may not eventually translate into a decisive margin for the BJP.

**KODA BEING
ARRESTED BY
THE JHARKHAND
VIGILANCE
BUREAU**

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thousand crore rupees is what Koda is being accused of having swindled as Jharkhand chief minister between 2006 and 2008.

by Amitabh Srivastava